ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Future in the past

Describe plans, predictions and events that were still future from an earlier viewpoint using would, was going to and was about to. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use future in the past to keep the future reference anchored inside a past narrative or report while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Describe plans, predictions and events that were still future from an earlier viewpoint using would, was going to and was about to.

MODEL

We knew the decision would affect the whole team.

would + base | was/were going to + base | was/were about to + base

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main future in the past patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses keep the future reference anchored inside a past narrative or report.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in narratives, reported plans, biographies and retrospective analysis.

Build meaning before form

Describe plans, predictions and events that were still future from an earlier viewpoint using would, was going to and was about to.

What future in the past communicates

Describe plans, predictions and events that were still future from an earlier viewpoint using would, was going to and was about to.

The central purpose is to keep the future reference anchored inside a past narrative or report. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

We knew the decision would affect the whole team.	a future event viewed from a past reporting point
She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.	an earlier plan that may or may not have happened
The train was about to leave when the signal changed.	an event expected immediately after a past moment

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: would + base | was/were going to + base | was/were about to + base. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “We knew the decision would affect the whole team.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Past prediction	would + base verb	We knew the decision would affect the whole team.
Past intention	was/were going to + base verb	She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.
Immediate future	was/were about to + base verb	The train was about to leave when the signal changed.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a future event viewed from a past reporting point	Past prediction
an earlier plan that may or may not have happened	Past intention
an event expected immediately after a past moment	Immediate future

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in narratives, reported plans, biographies and retrospective analysis. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04	05	06
would	base	was/were going to	base	was/were about to	base

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: keep the future reference anchored inside a past narrative or report.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits narratives, reported plans, biographies and retrospective analysis.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Past prediction	would + base verb	We knew the decision would affect the whole team.
Past intention	was/were going to + base verb	She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.
Immediate future	was/were about to + base verb	The train was about to leave when the signal changed.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

We knew the decision would affect the whole team.	a future event viewed from a past reporting point
She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.	an earlier plan that may or may not have happened
The train was about to leave when the signal changed.	an event expected immediately after a past moment

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use will when the viewpoint remains in the past.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not imply the intention happened unless the context confirms it.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use about to for a distant or unscheduled future.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a future event viewed from a past reporting point?

OPTIONS We knew the decision would affect the whole team. · She was going to call, but the meeting ran late. · The train was about to leave when the signal changed.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an earlier plan that may or may not have happened?

OPTIONS She was going to call, but the meeting ran late. · The train was about to leave when the signal changed. · We knew the decision would affect the whole team.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an event expected immediately after a past moment?

OPTIONS The train was about to leave when the signal changed. · We knew the decision would affect the whole team. · She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “We knew the decision would affect the whole team.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a future event viewed from a past reporting point · an earlier plan that may or may not have happened · an event expected immediately after a past moment

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an earlier plan that may or may not have happened · an event expected immediately after a past moment · a future event viewed from a past reporting point

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The train was about to leave when the signal changed.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an event expected immediately after a past moment · a future event viewed from a past reporting point · an earlier plan that may or may not have happened

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“We knew the decision would affect the whole team.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Past prediction / Past intention / Immediate future · Gap 2: a future event viewed from a past reporting point / an earlier plan that may or may not have happened / an event expected immediately after a past moment

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Past intention / Immediate future / Past prediction · Gap 2: an earlier plan that may or may not have happened / an event expected immediately after a past moment / a future event viewed from a past reporting point

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“The train was about to leave when the signal changed.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Immediate future / Past prediction / Past intention · Gap 2: an event expected immediately after a past moment / a future event viewed from a past reporting point / an earlier plan that may or may not have happened

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a future event viewed from a past reporting point: _____. Choose the model that expresses an earlier plan that may or may not have happened: _____. Choose the model that expresses an event expected immediately after a past moment: _____. Choose the model built with would + base verb: _____. Choose the model built with was/were going to + base verb: _____. Choose the model built with was/were about to + base verb: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

She was going to call, but the meeting ran late. · The train was about to leave when the signal changed. · We knew the decision would affect the whole team.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

We knew the decision _____ the whole team. She _____, but the meeting ran late. The train _____ when the signal changed. State the full structural pattern for Past prediction: _____. State the full structural pattern for Past intention: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “At that past moment, the effect was still in the future.” using the Past prediction pattern to express a future event viewed from a past reporting point.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Calling was her plan before the meeting delayed her.” using the Past intention pattern to express an earlier plan that may or may not have happened.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Departure was imminent at that time.” using the Immediate future pattern to express an event expected immediately after a past moment.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “At that past moment, the effect was still in the future.” using the Past prediction pattern to express a future event viewed from a past reporting point.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Past prediction to express a future event viewed from a past reporting point, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Past intention to express an earlier plan that may or may not have happened, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Immediate future to express an event expected immediately after a past moment, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

We knew the decision would affect the whole team.

Past prediction is the best match because a future event viewed from a past reporting point.

A2

She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.

Past intention is the best match because an earlier plan that may or may not have happened.

A3

The train was about to leave when the signal changed.

Immediate future is the best match because an event expected immediately after a past moment.

A4

a future event viewed from a past reporting point

The Past prediction pattern communicates a future event viewed from a past reporting point.

A5

an earlier plan that may or may not have happened

The Past intention pattern communicates an earlier plan that may or may not have happened.

A6

an event expected immediately after a past moment

The Immediate future pattern communicates an event expected immediately after a past moment.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Past prediction / a future event viewed from a past reporting point

The structure belongs to the Past prediction pattern. Its communicative purpose is a future event viewed from a past reporting point.

B2

Past intention / an earlier plan that may or may not have happened

The structure belongs to the Past intention pattern. Its communicative purpose is an earlier plan that may or may not have happened.

B3

Immediate future / an event expected immediately after a past moment

The structure belongs to the Immediate future pattern. Its communicative purpose is an event expected immediately after a past moment.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

We knew the decision would affect the whole team.

Past prediction: would + base verb.

C2

She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.

Past intention: was/were going to + base verb.

C3

The train was about to leave when the signal changed.

Immediate future: was/were about to + base verb.

C4

We knew the decision would affect the whole team.

Past prediction: would + base verb.

C5

She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.

Past intention: was/were going to + base verb.

C6

The train was about to leave when the signal changed.

Immediate future: was/were about to + base verb.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

would affect

Past prediction requires “would affect” in this model. would + base verb.

D2

was going to call

Past intention requires “was going to call” in this model. was/were going to + base verb.

D3

was about to leave

Immediate future requires “was about to leave” in this model. was/were about to + base verb.

D4

would + base verb

Past prediction is built as would + base verb.

D5

was/were going to + base verb

Past intention is built as was/were going to + base verb.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

We knew the decision would affect the whole team.

would + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended past prediction effect.

E2

She was going to call, but the meeting ran late.

was/were going to + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended past intention effect.

E3

The train was about to leave when the signal changed.

was/were about to + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended immediate future effect.

E4

We knew the decision would affect the whole team.

would + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended past prediction effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

We knew the decision would affect the whole team. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses would + base verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

She was going to call, but the meeting ran late. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses was/were going to + base verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The train was about to leave when the signal changed. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses was/were about to + base verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____